

University Students' Perceptions of AI Fortune-Telling: An Exploratory Study on Credibility and Motivations

Abstract

AI fortune-telling has gained popularity among young people. Existing literature has focused on young people's perceptions of AI fortune-telling and university students' views on traditional fortune-telling, but the usage motivations and perceived credibility of AI fortune-telling among university students remain under-explored. To address this gap, the paper investigates the major motivations, their overall trust level and credibility differences between users and non-users. Data was collected from 97 university student participants via questionnaires, and 3 users of AI fortune-telling via semi-structured interviews. Quantitative questionnaire data was analyzed by descriptive statistics and independent-samples t-test, while qualitative interview data provided complementary insights to the quantitative patterns. The findings indicate that convenience, accessibility, and curiosity are the primary motivations for student users. Overall perceived credibility is relatively low across the sample, though users rated the reference value of results significantly higher than non-users. This study contributes to bridging the academic gap between AI fortune-telling and university students' psychology and providing educators with more targeted guidance for supporting students' decision-making and stress coping in practice.

Key words: AI fortune-telling, motivation, credibility

1. Introduction

Recently, the integration of artificial intelligence (AI) technology with traditional fortune-telling has generated "AI fortune-telling", which has become increasingly popular among university students (Kimura, 2017; Reed, 2021). On the lifestyle app RedNote, the hashtag #DeepSeekFortune had over 47 million views by late September 2025. Many university students share their experiences about how to use DeepSeek to help with decision-making issues (Cheng, 2025, p. 17).

Compared with the high threshold of traditional fortune-telling, AI fortune-telling is much more accessible for young people and are considered to be more accurate (Lai & Zhou,

2023, p. 522). Existing studies have deeply investigated the black-box religiosity between traditional fortune-telling and AI (Davies, 2024; Nikolić, 2023) and explored the credibility and motivations behind university students' fortune-telling behaviors (Wang & Tai, 2025; Dong, 2010).

There is a noticeable gap in empirical studies on how university students perceive the credibility of AI fortune-telling and their primary motivations using it. Therefore, this study aims to fill these gaps by conducting an exploratory study into university students' perceptions of AI fortune-telling, centering on their views of the credibility of AI fortune-telling services, and motivations behind their engagement.

2. Literature Review

In past years, many researchers paid much attention to the behavior of university students using traditional fortune-telling or divination. Wang and Tai (2025) pointed out that university students use divination tools (e.g. Tarot cards) to ease uncertainty and insecurity, though they clearly realized Tarot cards cannot predict the future (p.72). And Dong (2010) showed that most online fortune-telling seekers are college students. They were enthusiastic about online fortune-telling, but did not fully accept the results of it (p. 86). However, Tarot cards and online fortune-telling still belong to traditional fortune-telling, and they did not take new technology (AI fortune-telling) into account. These studies also failed to accurately describe their level of trust in relevant fortune-telling methods. They focused more on the reasons for fortune-telling enthusiasm than detailed motivation analysis.

Another research stream explores the relationship between traditional fortune-telling and AI technology. Both Davies (2024) and Nikolić (2023) argued that AI and some aspects of fortune-telling or divination, such as Bazi and astrology, are associated as “epistemological frameworks”. These theoretical studies lay a foundation for verifying the credibility of AI fortune-telling methodologies and prove the feasibility of AI fortune-telling.

Few studies investigated young people's views on AI fortune-telling. For example, Lai and Zhou (2023) claimed that young people prefer AI fortune-telling methods over traditional ones (p. 522). Beyond direct studies on AI fortune-telling, other research has explored

people’s belief in AI-generated predictions, and Lee et al. (2024) specifically noted that psychological factors, like people’s attitudes towards AI, are leading contributors to this trust (p. 12). Moreover, Peng (2024) and Cheng (2025) both concluded that “algorithmic cognitive domestication” shapes young people’s belief in decision-making issues. However, these findings lack the demographic focus on university students and overlook the motivation for young people to choose AI fortune-telling.

Though previous work studies university students’ views on traditional fortune-telling, their perceptions of AI fortune-telling technology remain under-explored. While some research touches on AI-human relationships through fortune-telling among Chinese young people, the demographic focus on university students is lacking. To fill these gaps, this study investigates university students’ perceptions of AI fortune-telling, centering on their credibility of AI fortune-telling services, and the motivations behind their engagement.

3. Research Questions

- 1. What are the major motivations that drive university students to use AI fortune-telling tools?
- 2. To what extent do university students believe in the accuracy and reliability of AI fortune-telling?

4. Methods

4.1 Participants

This study involved 97 university students in completing the questionnaires designed for investigating AI fortune-telling behaviors, among whom 45 had used AI fortune-telling tools. As presented in Table 1, the participants displayed diverse backgrounds. Among all the AI fortune-telling users, 3 students were selected for in-depth interviews, and their detailed information is shown in Table 2.

Table 1: *Demographic Information of Surveyed Participants*

Variable	Characteristics	Frequency (N = 97)	Percent
----------	-----------------	-----------------------	---------

Gender	Male	34	35.05%
	Female	63	64.95%
Age	Under 18	0	0%
	18-20	66	68.04%
	21-23	30	30.93%
	Over 23	1	1.03%
Major	Arts & Humanities	3	3.09%
	Science & Engineering	48	49.48%
	Business & Economics	41	42.27%
	Other	5	5.15%
Year of study	Year 1 undergraduate	15	15.46%
	Year 2 undergraduate	43	44.33%
	Year 3 undergraduate	9	9.28%
	Year 4 undergraduate	28	28.87%
	Postgraduate	2	2.06%
Have used an AI fortune-telling tool	Yes	45	46.39%
	No	52	53.61%

Table 2: Demographic Information of Interviewees

ID	Year of study	Major	Gender
Kelly	Year 1 undergraduate	Urban and Rural Planning	Female
Zack	Year 2 undergraduate	Finance	Male
Adler	Year 3 undergraduate	Electrical and Computer Engineering	Male

4.2 Data collection

Data was collected through questionnaires and interviews. The questionnaire collected data on the motivation and credibility of participants in AI fortune-telling, and it contained four sections: 1) basic participants’ details; 2) usage habits (via multiple-choice questions); 3) motivation measurement (with a Likert 5-point scale); 4) perceived credibility assessment

(also with a Likert 5-point scale).

Table 3: *Likert 5-point Scale in the Questionnaire*

Strongly disagree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly agree
1	2	3	4	5

After collecting the data, semi-structured interviews were held with 3 students who have used AI fortune-telling tools. Each lasted approximately 10 minutes through Tencent Meeting. Interviews covered: 1) previous AI fortune-telling experiences; 2) motivations for using AI fortune-telling tools; 3) perceptions on the AI fortune-telling predictions. All interviews were audio-recorded and anonymized.

4.3 Data analysis

For the quantitative data in questionnaires, they were first cleaned and organized. The Likert-scale data concerning motivation and credibility were analyzed through descriptive statistics (e.g., mean, standard deviation) and reliability tests (T-test) by Excel and SPSS to identify driving factors and trust levels.

For the qualitative data in interviews, the recordings were transcribed into texts and categorized into different patterns related to students’ AI fortune-telling experiences. These themes were analyzed to gain deeper insights into perceptions, supporting quantitative findings.

5. Results

5.1 Motivations

Descriptive statistics were applied to analyze the motivations of participants with AI fortune-telling experience (N=45) using data from the questionnaire’s “Motivation Measurement” section. Results are summarized in Table 4.

Table 4: *Motivations of Users and Descriptive Statistics*

Dimension	N	Mean	S.D.	Importance Ranking
Curiosity	45	3.78	0.85	3

Alleviating anxiety about future development	45	3.11	1.15	5
Obtain emotional support	45	3.29	1.18	4
Recommendations from others	45	2.93	1.14	6
“Algorithmic objectivity” of AI fortune-telling	45	2.62	0.98	7
Accessibility	45	3.84	1.15	2
Convenience	45	4.04	0.98	1

As shown in Table 4, the mean score for the “Convenience” dimension was the highest (Mean = 4.04, S.D. = 0.98), followed by “Accessibility” (Mean = 3.84, S.D. = 1.15) and “Curiosity” (Mean = 3.78, S.D. = 0.85). All three dimensions had mean scores above 3.5, indicating that convenience, accessibility, and curiosity were the major motivations for university students to use AI fortune-telling tools, with convenience being the most prominent one. Notably, convenience (focused on ease of use, e.g., simple operation steps) differs from accessibility (referring to easy availability of services).

Moreover, during the interviews, all three identified “convenience” as the primary reason for their use of AI fortune-telling. Among them, Zack further distinguished AI fortune-telling from traditional fortune-telling, explaining:

The reason I chose AI is that it is much more convenient than traditional methods, I can get results with just a few clicks. (Zack)

For Zack, convenience was not only the driver for using AI fortune-telling but also the reason he avoided traditional practices.

5.2 Perceived Credibility

Descriptive statistics were also employed to investigate the perceived credibility of AI fortune-telling among all participants (N = 97), with results presented in Table 5.

Table 5: Perceived Credibility of All Participants and Descriptive Statistics

Items	N	Mean	S.D.
16. The results of AI fortune-telling can reflect an individual’s real	97	2.42	0.97

fortune or development trend.			
17. The algorithmic logic of AI fortune-telling is reliable.	97	2.88	0.94
18. AI fortune-telling influences the direction of my decision-making.	97	2.49	1.04
19. Even if there are differences between the results of AI fortune-telling and personal expectations, it still has reference value for me.	97	2.93	1.06
20. Whether an AI fortune-telling tool discloses its algorithmic principles will affect my trust in it.	97	3.26	1.14
21. The results of AI fortune-telling are not affected by subjective factors.	97	2.59	1.01

Table 5 shows that the mean scores of the six items were mostly below 3, except item 20 about algorithmic transparency (Mean = 3.26, S.D. = 1.14). This pattern reflected that the overall perceived credibility was relatively low, while also suggesting that most participants were concerned about algorithm transparency.

Aligning with the quantitative finding in Table 5, all interviewees mentioned they were concerned about “algorithm logic” when using AI fortune-telling services. Adler specifically emphasized algorithm transparency:

I am more concerned about the algorithm principles. I think AI, based on data from the entire network, is somewhat credible. (Adler)

Adler’s remark echoes the algorithm transparency focus identified in Table 5, even as the sample largely distrusted these tools.

However, the previous analysis focused on the perceived credibility of the full sample. Several differences emerged between users and non-users of AI fortune-telling, so an independent-samples t-test was conducted to compare their perceived credibility.

Table 6: T-test Results on Perceived Credibility Between Users and Non-Users

I have used AI fortune-telling tools. (Mean±SD)	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>
---	----------	----------

	Yes (N=45)	No (N=52)		
16. The results of AI fortune-telling can reflect an individual's real fortune or development trend.	2.58±0.92	2.29±1.00	1.479	0.142
17. The algorithmic logic of AI fortune-telling is reliable.	3.00±0.83	2.77±1.02	1.230	0.222
18. AI fortune-telling influences the direction of my decision-making.	2.67±1.04	2.35±1.03	1.521	0.132
19. Even if there are differences between the results of AI fortune-telling and personal expectations, it still has reference value for me.	3.27±0.91	2.63±1.10	3.043	0.003**
20. Whether an AI fortune-telling tool discloses its algorithmic principles will affect my trust in it.	3.24±1.13	3.27±1.16	-0.106	0.916
21. The results of AI fortune-telling are not affected by subjective factors.	2.76±0.98	2.44±1.02	1.537	0.128
* $p < 0.05$ ** $p < 0.01$				

Table 6 illustrates that the ratings of users for Item 19 (concerning the use of the reference value of results in case of conflict with personal expectations) were significantly higher than those of non-users ($p < 0.01$). No significant differences between the two groups were found for other items.

6. Discussion

In terms of RQ1, this study found that major motivations were convenience, accessibility and curiosity. The results echo the findings of Cheng (2025) and Wang & Tai (2025), who argued that curiosity was the major motivation. This observation can be accounted for by the “black-box nature” of AI and “mystery stems” of fortune-telling. Supernatural forces of fortune-telling and the lack of transparency in algorithms made AI fortune-telling more uncertain and mysterious, which in turn arouse people's interest. (Cheng, 2025; Singler, 2020; Gore et al., 2018).

Regarding RQ2, participants demonstrated a low level of belief in the accuracy and reliability of AI fortune-telling, and users of such fortune-telling tools rated the reference value of results significantly higher than non-users. The findings align with Lai and Zhou's (2023) research, which showed that users of AI fortune-telling were willing to use AI-generated results as personal guidance. However, such findings diverge from Lee et al.'s (2024) conclusion: participants perceived fictitious AI predictions as highly believable (p. 4). A plausible explanation is that Lee et al. (2024) included both elderly people and young people in their study, and elderly people tended to believe the predictions more, which may have led to higher overall credibility. Future research can be done by obtaining a larger sample and exploring the underlying logic of "users believing in AI fortune-telling results", such as whether it is related to users' experience with the tools or other aspects.

7. Conclusion

This article investigated the university students' key motivations for using and trust level of AI fortune-telling by adopting mixed methods. It confirmed convenience, accessibility, and curiosity as three major motivations and found that their overall perceived credibility was relatively low across the sample. The research bridges the academic gap between AI fortune-telling and the psychology of university students and helps educators provide more targeted guidance on students' decision-making and stress coping in practice. However, there were some limitations. First, the sample size was relatively small. Second, the self-reported data may have introduced response bias. Third, it lacked comparison with traditional fortune-telling. Thus, future research should include a comparison with traditional fortune-telling and explore the long-term behavioral effects of AI fortune-telling use.

(Total Words: 1576)

References

- Cheng, Z. (2025). Cognitive domestication in the age of algorithms: A study of the mechanisms by which AI divination influences the decision-making of Generation Z youth. *Advances in Social Behavior Research*, 16(7), 14-25.
<https://doi.org/10.54254/2753-7102/2025.26541>
- Davies, H. (2024, June). *From I-Ching to AI: Interrogating digital divination*. Paper presented at the 29th International Symposium on Electronic Art (ISEA), Brisbane (Meanjin), Queensland Australia. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/381663883_From_I-Ching_to_AI_Interrogating_Digital_Divination
- Dong, X. (2010). Dang dai qing nian ren re zhong wang luo mi xin de she hui xue fen xi [Sociological analysis of contemporary young people's enthusiasm for Internet superstition]. *China Youth Study*, (6), 82-86.
<https://doi.org/10.19633/j.cnki.11-2579/d.2010.06.014>
- Gore, R. J., Lemos, C., Shults, F. L., & Wildman, W. J. (2018). Forecasting changes in religiosity and existential security with an agent-based model. *Journal of Artificial Societies and Social Simulation*, 21(1), 1-4.
<https://doi.org/10.18564/jasss.3596>
- Kimura, T. (2017). Robotics and AI in the sociology of religion: A human in imago roboticae. *Social Compass*, 64(1), 6-22.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/0037768616683326>
- Lai, Y., & Zhou, X. (2023). Trust crisis or algorithm boost? An investigation of artificial intelligence divination applications in China. In H. Degen & S. Ntoa (Eds.), *Artificial intelligence in HCI: 4th International Conference, AI-HCI 2023, held as part of the 25th HCI International Conference, HCII 2023, Copenhagen, Denmark, July 23–28, 2023, Proceedings, Part II*. (pp. 516-524). Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-35894-4_38
- Lee, E., Pataranutaporn, P., Amores, J., & Maes, P. (2024). Super-intelligence or superstition?

Exploring psychological factors influencing belief in AI predictions about personal behavior.

<https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2408.06602>

Nikolić, L. (2023). ECS-Ecrea Early Career Scholar Prize winner - An astrological genealogy of artificial intelligence: From 'pseudo-sciences' of divination to sciences of prediction. *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 26(2), 131-146.

<https://doi.org/10.1177/13675494231164874>

Peng, L. (2024). Divination reimaged: The impact of online platforms on traditional beliefs among Chinese netizens. *Lecture Notes in Education Psychology and Public Media*, 73, 135-140.

<https://doi.org/10.54254/2753-7048/73/20241055>

Reed, R. (2021). A.I. in religion, A.I. for religion, A.I. and religion: Towards a theory of religious studies and artificial intelligence. *Religions*, 12(6), 401.

<https://doi.org/10.3390/rel12060401>

Singler, B. (2020). The AI creation meme: A case study of the new visibility of religion in artificial intelligence discourse. *Religions*, 11(5), 253.

<https://doi.org/10.3390/rel11050253>

Wang, F., & Tai, H. (2025). The spiritual dilemmas and solutions of college students' online astrology: Based on an investigation of the horoscope and Tarot divination behaviors of 2100 college students. *Science and Atheism*, (1), 59-73.

<https://doi.org/CNKI:SUN:KXWS.0.2025-01-006>

Appendix A. *Questionnaire*

University Students' Perceptions of AI Fortune-Telling: An Exploratory Research on Credibility and Motivations

Dear college student friends:

Hello! This questionnaire aims to explore college students' perceptions, usage motivations, and credibility evaluations of AI fortune-telling (such as Bazi (Four Pillars of Destiny) charting, Zi Wei Dou Shu (Purple Star Astrology) calculation, constellation fortune analysis, AI recognition of facial features and palmistry, online Tarot card divination, and real-time fortune prediction and life guidance based on generative AI, all conducted via artificial intelligence tools like DeepSeek). All data will only be used for academic research, and your personal information will be strictly kept confidential. The questionnaire will take approximately 2-3 minutes to complete. There are no right or wrong answers to your responses, so please fill it out based on your true situation. Thank you for your support and cooperation!

Part 1: Basic Information

1. I am

☐ Male

☐ Female

2. I am

☐ Under 18

☐ 18-20

☐ 21-23

☐ Over 23

3. I am

☐ Arts & Humanities

☐ Science & Engineering

☐ Business & Economics

☐ Other ____

4. I am

☐ Year 1 undergraduate

☐ Year 2 undergraduate

☐ Year 3 undergraduate

☐ Year 4 undergraduate

☐ Postgraduate

Part 2: Usage Habits

5. I have used AI fortune-telling tools.

☐ Yes

☐ No

6. I have used the following tools.

☐ DeepSeek

☐ Other AI chatbots, e.g., ChatGPT, Doubao

☐ Dedicated AI fortune-telling apps, mini-programs, or web pages, for example, the AI function of a certain constellation app

☐ Other ____

7. I have been using AI fortune-telling tools with a frequency of

☐ Only used 1-2 times

☐ Occasionally: 1-2 times/month

☐ Frequently: 1-2 times/week

☐ Always: 3 times or more per week

8. I usually use AI fortune-telling in these scenarios:

☐ Academic planning, such as exams, further education

☐ Career development, such as internships, employment directions

☐ Emotional relationships, such as romantic relationships, interpersonal conflicts

☐ Life decisions, such as travel, consumption

☐ Just curious

☐ Other ____

Part 3: Motivation Measurement (Likert Scale)

Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements:

(1 = Strongly disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Neutral, 4 = Agree, 5 = Strongly agree)

9. I am curious about how AI algorithms generate “fortune-telling results”, so I tried to use.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

10. I use AI for fortune-telling to alleviate my anxiety about future academic/career development.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

11. I hope to obtain emotional support (such as alleviating loneliness and confusion) through AI fortune-telling.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

12. Recommendations from people around me (classmates, friends) prompted me to use AI for fortune-telling.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

13. Compared with traditional fortune-telling (such as offline masters and tarot cards), the “algorithmic objectivity” of AI fortune-telling is more appealing to me.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

14. I use it because it is more accessible than traditional fortune-telling.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

15. The convenience of AI fortune-telling (such as being available at any time and not requiring offline appointments) is the main reason I choose it.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

Part 4: Perceived Credibility Assessment (Likert Scale)

Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements:

(1 = Strongly disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Neutral, 4 = Agree, 5 = Strongly agree)

16. The results of AI fortune-telling can reflect an individual's real fortune / development trend.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

17. The algorithmic logic of AI fortune-telling is reliable. e.g., based on big data or specific models.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

18. AI fortune-telling influences the direction of my decision-making.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

19. Even if there are differences between the results of AI fortune-telling and personal expectations, it still has reference value for me.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

20. Whether an AI fortune-telling tool discloses its algorithmic principles (such as how results are generated based on date of birth) will affect my trust in it.

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

21. The results of AI fortune-telling are not affected by subjective factors (such as the preferences of tool developers).

Strongly disagree ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 Strongly agree

Thank you again for taking the precious time to complete the questionnaire! Wish you success in your studies and a happy life!

Appendix B. *Interview Questions*

1. How did you get to know about AI fortune-telling tools first? (like DeepSeek, fortune-telling apps) What are the commonly used tools, and how frequently are they used?
2. If you were to choose to predict your future with AI, what aspects would you focus on the most? (e.g. studies, relationships, career)? What is the main reason for choosing AI over traditional fortune-telling (Tarot, Eight Characters)?
3. How accurate, in your estimation, are AI-generated fortune-telling results? Have you ever come across a situation where the results "came true" or "were inaccurate"? If so, could you please elaborate?
4. What could be the factors that influence your trust most towards AI fortune-telling? Is it the logic of the algorithm, the experience of the use, or the evaluation of others?
5. Do you think there is a fundamental difference between AI fortune-telling and traditional fortune-telling? If yes, then what do you think is the biggest difference?
6. Has the use of AI fortune-telling, in any way, influenced your mentality (such as anxiety relief) or decision-making? If yes, then what was it specifically?

****Acknowledgment Statement****

I acknowledge that I have used AI-powered writing tools, such as ChatGPT, in writing the assignment.

1. I used DeepSeek and Tencent Yuanbao to help with the literature search on “literature review” part. This AI found out article “Dang dai qing nian ren re zhong wang luo mi xin de she hui xue fen xi [Sociological analysis of contemporary young people’s enthusiasm for Internet superstition]” and “The spiritual dilemmas and solutions of college students’ online astrology: Based on an investigation of the horoscope and Tarot divination behaviors of 2100 college students”.
2. Both DeepSeek and Doubao were used for providing grammar and punctuation guidance. Doubao was specifically asked to identify grammatical errors and offer detailed explanations for them.
3. DeepSeek and Doubao not only helped provide suggestions on expressions, but also served to search for synonyms.
4. I used Elicit (<https://elicit.com/>) to search for literature, and I also verified each piece to make sure it is genuine.